THE BANGLADESH REVOLUTION AND ITS AFTERMATH

Talukder Maniruzzaman

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THE BANGLADESH REVOLUTION AND ITS AFTERMATH

TALUKDER MANIRUZZAMAN

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To my wife
U.A.B. RAZIA AKTER BANU
who shared my quest to understand
the Bangladesh Revolution

PREFACE TO THE SECOND EDITION

In his preface to the second edition of *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte*, Karl Marx wrote, "A revision of the present work would have robbed it of its peculiar colouring". It is the same feeling which prevented me from making any revision of the present study. As I wrote in the preface to the first edition of the book, "My views of political life have been indelibly coloured by my experience in observing at first hand the grandeur of the people of Bangladesh who brought about the cataclysic change that took place in 1971." I also had the fortune to observe directly the dramatic developments in Bangladesh that followed the traumatic birth of the newest nation. The book is reprinted without modification in the hope that the reader will gain a real feel of the Bangladesh revolution of 1971 and its aftermath.

The only addition to this reprint of the book is a select bibliography. The bibliography consists, primarily, of the documents and literature published in Bengali on the open and underground political parties, student political organizations, Bangladesh Government-in-exile and the liberation war of 1971. As these documents and literature constitute parts of the primary sources of this study, the addendum accentuates the flavour of the book.

The book was first published in December 1980. It went out of print by the end of 1982. Since that time I have been receiving innumerable inquiries about the book from both within and outside Bangladesh. I thank Mohiuddin Ahmed of University Press Limited, Dhaka, for publishing this edition of the book.

January 1988 TALUKDER MANIRUZZAMAN

PREFACE

During the last few years I have often thought of something Krupskaya, Lenin's wife and comrade, is reported to have said in the latter years of her life, that "only one who has lived through a revolution knows the grandeur of it". My views of political life have been indelibly coloured by my experience in observing at first hand the grandeur of the people of Bangladesh who brought about the cataclysmic change that took place in 1971. Nevertheless, as a student of the social sciences, I have sought to understand events in Bangladesh in as thoughtful a manner as possible. It has been an inner intellectual urge that has sustained me in this pursuit, despite an atmosphere that has frequently been uncongenial for rigorous and painstaking research.

This book had its origin in a study in 1969 of the political parties in former united Pakistan. As part of that study, I collected party documents and literature and obtained information about the backgrounds of leading party personnel. In this connection I went in late 1969 on a research trip to West Pakistan, visiting the offices of various political parties in Karachi, Lahore and Peshawar and interviewing a large number of the more prominent political leaders of West Pakistan.

Early in 1970, soon after I began my writing, the new military government of Yahya Khan announced its intention to hold the first general elections in Pakistan. I decided to hold up my work in order to incorporate a chapter on the performance of the parties during the campaign and at the polls. But from then on events in Pakistan moved swiftly and dramatically, and my work had to be put to one side. After the army crackdown on East Bengal on the night of 25 March 1971, survival itself became the principal problem for all intellectuals in Bangladesh, myself included. Nevertheless, throughout the entire nine-month period of army occupation I remained in Bangladesh, gaining first hand knowledge about the moves and strategies adopted by the Pakistan army in its effort to suppress the grim resistance it encountered.

After the liberation of Bangladesh—on 16 December 1971—I set about gathering materials on the liberation war, interviewing a large number of Mukti Bahini (liberation army) members and leaders and collecting newspapers published by the various resistance groups in Calcutta. I visited Calcutta and Delhi in February 1973 to find out more about India's role in the liberation of Bangladesh. The present study incorporates the results of these different strands of activity.

I am grateful to a large number of political leaders of Pakistan, Bangladesh and West Bengal, who not only supplied me with rare party documents but also consented to long interviews. A list of these persons is provided in the Appendix.

Dr. Craig Baxter lent me his personal collections of the most recent books and articles on Pakistan and Bangladesh which had been published abroad and were not available in Dacca. My very close friend Professor Marcus F. Franda made suggestions that contributed to substantial improvements in the first draft. Dr. Peter Lyon kindly read and gave his comments on Chapter VI. My greatest indebtedness is to Professor W.H. Morris-Jones who went through the whole manuscript meticulously and gave thoughtful suggestions which led to both substantive and stylistic improvements.

The research for this study, and the writing of the manuscript, had to be carried out in addition to my departmental administrative duties and a heavy teaching load. I coluld never have completed this study without the help of my wife, U.A.B. Razia Akter Banu, who not only provided a congenial home but also acted as a comrade and critic throughout the work.

I must also thank Mrs. Vonnie Franda who read the proofs of the typed manuscript. My thanks are also due to Mr. Manzurul Islam of Bangladesh Books International and Mr. Golam Rasul Mallick of Eastern Commercial Service for their help in the publication of the book.

Needless to say, despite the help of all these people, any failings of the present work are mine alone.

February 1979 TALUKDER MANIRUZZAMAN

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ABBREVIATIONS

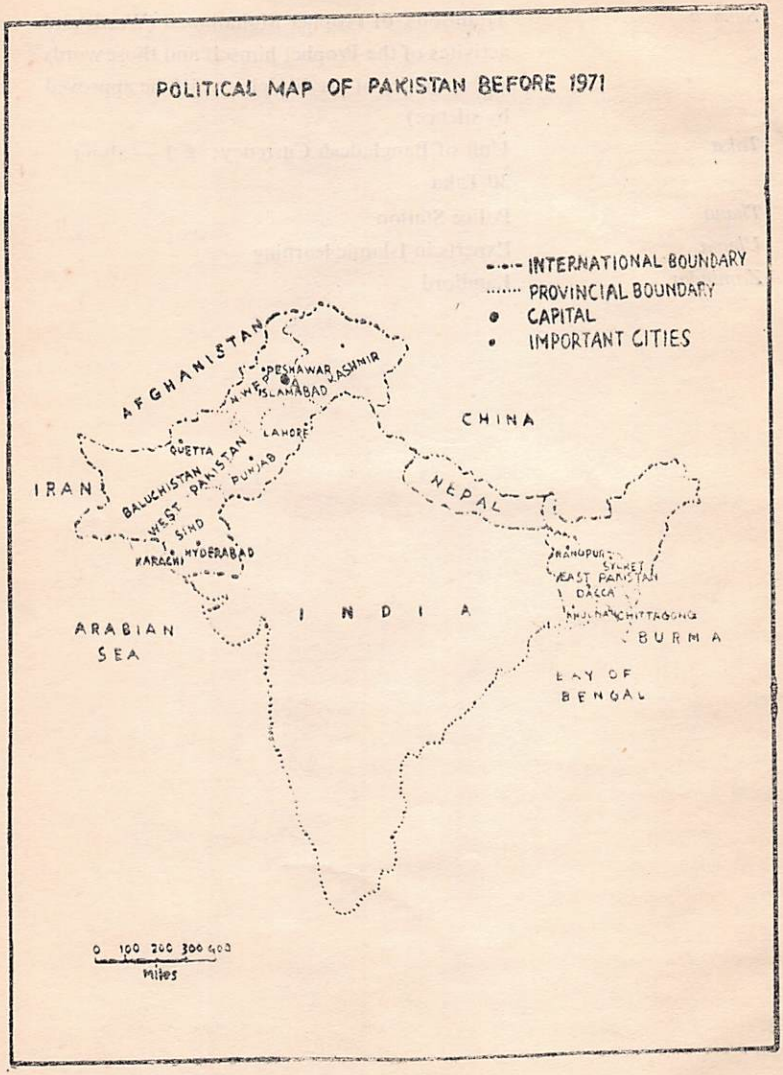
AL	Awami League
BAKSAL	Bangladesh Krishak Sramik Awami League
BCL	Bangladesh Chattra League
BCP	Banglar Communist Party
BCPL	Bangladesher Communist Party Leninbadi
BSF	Border Security Force
BSS	Biplobi Shainik Sangstha
CCCR	Coordination Committee of Communist Revolutionaries
COA	Committee of Action
COP	Combined Opposition Parties
CPI	Communist Party of India
CPM	Communist Party Marxist
CPML	Communist Party Marxist-Leninist
DC	Deputy Commissioner
EBCPML	East Bengal Communist Party Marxists Leninist
EBR	East Bengal Regiment
EBWM	East Bengal Workers Movement
EPAL	East Pakistan Awami League
EPAML	East Pakistan Awami Muslim League
EPCP	East Pakistan Communist Party
EPCPML	East Pakistan Communist Party Marxist Leninist
EPMAL	East Pakistan Muslim Awami League
EPMSL	East Pakistan Muslim Students League
EPR	East Pakistan Rifles
EPSL	East Pakistan Students League
EPSU	East Pakistan Students Union
FWP	Food for Works Project
GOJ	Gana Oikkya Jote
ICS	Indian Civil Service
ICS	Islami Chattra Sangha
IDL	Islamic Democratic League
ILO	International Labour Organisation
IPS	Indian Police Service/Indian Political Service
JSD	Jatio Samajtantric Dal
KSP	Krishak Sramic Party
LFO	Legal Framework Order

MNA	Member of National Assembly
MP	Member of Parliament
MPA	Member of Provincial Assembly
NAP	National Awami Party
NSF	National Students Federation
NWFP	North-West Frontier Province
PDP	Pakistan Democratic Party
PML	Pakistan Muslim League
PPP	Pakistan Peoples' Party
PPR	Political Parties Regulation
RTC	Round Table Conference
SCA	Students' Committee of Action
SDO	Subdivisional Officer

GLOSSARY

Al-Badar	Soldiers of the first battle fought by Prophet Mohammad in Arabia
Al-Shams	The Sun, name of a company of soldiers of Badar Battle
Amar Sonar Bangla	My Golden Bengal
Ansar	Helper (Civil armed guards)
Bangabandhu	Friend of Bengal
Bastuhara	The rootless pavement and slum dwellers
Bazar	Market place
Chakma	Name of a tribe in the district of Chittagong Hill Tracts
Char	Silted islet of a river
Ghat	Docks
Gherao	To encircle
Hartal	Strike
Hazong	Name of a tribe in the district of Mymensingh
Jagirdars	Landholders
Jawans	Ordinary soldiers
Joy Bangla	Glory to Bengal
Krishak Sramik Raj	Rule of peasants and workers
Madrassah	Islamic Religious Institute
Mahajans	Money lenders
Mujahid	Defender of the faith (from Jihad, Holy war)
Maulana	Religious leader
Mufassil Town	Small town surrounded by countryside
Mukti	Emancipation
Mukti Bahini	Liberation army
Quran	The holy book of the Muslims revealed to Prophet Mohammad
Rajakars	Volunteers
Sangram Parishad	Resistance Committee
Santal	Name of a tribe in North Bengal

Seer	Weight of about 2 lbs
Shahid Minar	Martyr's Memorial
Sunnah	Traditions of Prophet Mohammad (Words and activites of the Prophet himself and those words and activities of his disciples which he approved by silence)
Taka	Unit of Bangladesh Currency; £ 1 — about 30 Taka
Thana	Police Station
Ulema	Experts in Islamic learning
Zamindar	Landlord


POLITICAL MAP OF PAKISTAN BEFORE 1971
INTERNATIONAL BOUNDARY
PROVINCIAL BOUNDARY
CAPITAL
IMPORTANT CITIES
AFGHANISTAN
PESHAWAR
KASHMIR
ISLAMABAD
LAHORE
CHINA
QUETTA
BALUCHISTAN
WEST PAKISTAN
PUNJAB
IRAN
NEPAL
SIND
KARACHI
HYDERABAD
RANGPUR
SYLHET
EAST PAKISTAN
DACCA
KHULNA
CHITTAGONG
BURMA
INDIA
ARABIAN SEA
BAY OF BENGAL
0 100 200 300 400
miles

CHAPTER VI

GUERRILLA WAR AND THE INDIAN ROLE

Machiavelli warned the *Prince* centuries ago: "When once the people have taken arms against you, there will never be lacking foreigners to assist them."[1] Given the strained relationship between India and Pakistan, and given present-day "great power" rivalries, support to Bangladesh rebels from neighbouring India and some of the great powers was perhaps inevitable.

At the governmental level, some of the Awami League leaders contacted a top official of the Indian Deputy High Commissioner's office at Dacca in the first week of March 1971, when they began to apprehend the use of military force to suppress the non-cooperation movement. The official concerned then went to Delhi, on the pretext of his daughter's illness, and came back on March 8 after having consulted the "appropriate authorities." He assured the AL leaders that some help in terms of food-supply at the border and political asylum for AL leaders would be available.[2]

Soon after the military crackdown on March 25, Indira Gandhi called a meeting of her Political Affairs Committee, consisting of Y.B. Chavan, Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed, Jagjivan Ram, and Swaran Singh. D.P. Dhar, Chairman of the Policy Planning Committee of the Ministry of External Affairs, Government of India and the three chiefs of the Indian defence services attended the meeting by invitation. The meeting discussed the propriety of Indian military intervention in support of the Bangladesh rebels. The Chiefs of the Indian defence services reportedly argued that the Indian armed forces were unprepared at the moment for military intervention, which could lead to all-out war with Pakistan.

The Chinese might also have created trouble for India on the Tibetan border and North-East Frontier Agency (NEFA) regions in the East. The Five-Year Defence Plan launched by the Indian government in 1964, to modernise and expand India's defence forces in order to be able to cope with simultaneous attack by Pakistan and China, was not yet fully implemented. Moreover, about four divisions of the Indian army in Eastern Command were engaged in meeting the demands of internal security. Several additional divisions were to be raised and a new operational and logistical infrastructure was to be built before the Indian armed forces could launch a "lightning campaign" in Bangladesh.

On the recommendation of the Service Chiefs, the Political Affairs Committee decided against military intervention at that moment. The Border Security Force (BSF) of India was given permission to lend all possible help to the Mukti Bahini, then engaged in pitched battles with Pakistan army columns in various areas. The BSF was, however, given strict order not to confront the Pakistan forces directly. In the second phase of the revolution, the BSF men entered Chuadanga, Meherpur, Rajshahi, Dinajpur and Sylhet to support the EBR/EPR from the rear. At that time the BSF supplied arms and ammunition to the Mukti Bahini in places where there were no trained EBR or EPR. When the Mukti Bahini later met with reverses, the BSF supplied large amounts of explosives to the Mukti Bahini soldiers for the purpose of destroying bridges and road communications. The BSF also provided expert services in some places and gave artillery support to the Mukti Bahini, while the latter retreated towards the Indian border.[3]

Formation of the Government-in-Exile

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was arrested on the night of March 25, 1971 by the Commandos of Special Service Group (SSG) under General Osman Mitha, the head of SSG, and taken to West Pakistan, where he was kept in solitary confinement in a district town until January 1972. At the time of his last meeting with other AL leaders, on the night of March 25, he was reportedly pressed by Tajuddin Ahmed to flee. One EPR Major also came and requested Sheikh Mujib to escape.

Sheikh Mujib's decision not to flee was probably influenced by his past experiences. He may have expected that the army's ruthless attempts to suppress the movement for autonomy would be only temporary. Then, as in 1969, his arrest would initiate another massive popular movement and he would again be released to ride the crest of a new wave of popularity. He might also have thought that while fleeing he might be killed, either by extremist students displeased with his temporising on the issue of independence or by the Pakistan forces who would then put the blame on the extremists. He might have also felt that if he fled, the Pakistan army would in its fury resort to massive killing and destruction of property in Dacca. However, while he stayed on at home, Sheikh Mujib asked his colleagues either to hide themselves or to flee.[4]

Tajuddin Ahmed, General Secretary of the AL, together with another AL leader, Amirul Islam, fled together from Dacca. They crossed the Kushtia border on March 30 and contacted a BSF sentry who sent a message to Calcutta. A helicopter was sent to take them to Calcutta where Lt. General Rustamjee and Gokul Majumder of the BSF welcomed them on behalf of the Indian government. They were later flown to Delhi on April 2, where Tajuddin met Mrs. Indira Gandhi to explain his plans to form a government-in-exile.

With Mrs. Gandhi's assurance of all possible help, Tajuddin came back to Calcutta on April 4. In the meantime, most of the AL leaders and elected members of the National Assembly of Pakistan (MNA) and the Provincial Assembly of East Bengal (MPA) had fled from the country. They were finally able to meet in Calcutta, where they formed the Constituent Assembly of Bangladesh in exile. The formal meeting of the Constituent Assembly was held on April 17 on Bangladesh soil in a mango-grove at Baddayanattala (named "Mujibnagar" by the government-in-exile), a village in Meherpur sub-division bordering West Bengal.[5] With a Declaration of Independence, the Constituent Assembly proclaimed the sovereignty of Bangladesh, electing Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as President and Syed Nazrul Islam as Vice-President. According to the terms of this Declaration, the Vice-President was empowered to act as President of Bangladesh in the absence of Sheikh Mujib.[6]

After Syed Nazrul Islam's elevation to the position of Acting President, Tajuddin as Prime Minister formed a cabinet from among the seniormost office-bearers of the AL, consisting of Khandokar Mushtaq Ahmed, Mansur Ali and A.H.M. Kamruzzaman.[7] The government was deliberately kept small so that there could not be too many aspirants for ministership and disappointed members could not create fissures within the AL. The cabinet appointed Colonel Ataul Ghani Usmani, 52, a former officer of the Pakistan army and an AL MNA, Commander-in-Chief of the liberation armed forces. Some prominent officers of the "East Pakistan" government, including 13 CSPs, fled to India and joined the Bangladesh Government-in-exile.

The AL Government-in-exile had initially a fund of Rupees 135 million ($19 million). This fund consisted of the money looted from the banks and treasuries of "East Pakistan" during the second phase of the revolution and deposited into a Bangladesh government consolidated fund. Rupees 40 million of this fund was converted into Indian currency and the rest of the money consisted of currency notes which were demonetised by the Pakistan government. Rupees 15 million were received by the exile government from voluntary organisations and state governments in India.[8] All foreign tours of the nominees of the Government-in-exile were financed by the Indian government. Those Bengali officers in the foreign service of Pakistan who defected to Bangladesh were financed by voluntary contributions of Bengalis living abroad and by Indian diplomatic missions.

There was, of course, a degree of factionalism within the Government-in-exile and among those AL leaders who were in Calcutta. One section, headed by Khandokar Mushtaq, Minister in charge of foreign affairs, was reportedly in favour of some sort of compromise with the Pakistan rulers on the basis of an agreement that would ensure the release of Sheikh Mujib and the autonomy of Bangladesh in the context of one Pakistan. Such agreement was to be brought about through the good offices of the United States government. Mushtaq Ahmed was reported to have maintained contact with the Consul-General of U.S.A. in Calcutta for this purpose. Tajuddin Ahmed, being opposed to the idea, therefore, adopted a policy of by-passing Mushtaq Ahmed. He made Abdus Samad, a former member of

NAP (pro-Moscow), political advisor to the cabinet and Samad performed the functions of a de facto Foreign Minister.

Samad headed the Bangladesh delegation sent to the World Peace Conference held in Budapest in April 1971. Mushtaq Ahmed's name was announced in the Press as the leader of the Bangladesh delegation to the United Nations General Assembly session of 1971, but he was finally omitted from the team and Justice Abu Sayeed Chowdhury was selected to lead the delegation instead.[9] Tajuddin Ahmed was thus able to isolate Mushtaq Ahmed and pursue a tough line toward Pakistan. He was also able to establish a close relationship with the Indian government.

Siddhartha Sankar Roy, later Chief Minister of West Bengal and at that time a Minister in the Indian government, was the main liaison between the Bangladesh Government-in-exile and the Indian government. A.K. Roy, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Government of India, was stationed in Calcutta to coordinate day-to-day contact with the Bangladesh government. For any serious issue, direct contact was maintained between Tajuddin and Indira Gandhi, either through Siddhartha Sankar Roy or D. P. Dhar.[10]

Building up the Mukti Bahini

From May 15 the Indian army began to help build the Mukti Bahini. Major-General Sarkar of the Indian army was appointed as the Chief Liaison Officer between the Bangladesh Government-in-exile and the Indian army, with Brigadier Das on constant duty at the Bangladesh Government Headquarters. In the meantime Major Safiullah, Major Khaled Musharraf and Colonel Usmani met at Teliapara, a place in Sylhet district bordering India, and prepared a basic paper on the strategy of the liberation war.

When contemplating alternative strategies, Colonel Usmani relied on his background of active participation in the South-East Asia sector during the Second World War. There he had noticed and been impressed by the Japanese tactic, as used in Indonesia and Burma, of a two-pronged attack, by regular troops and guerrillas, on allied forces. According to Usmani's formulations, regular forces could attack the enemy positions from the front while locally-manned guerrillas attacked from the rear,

Khaled Musharraf, whose previous training had been with the commandos, argued that as weaker force in the partisan war the Mukti Bahini would have to turn itself into a guerrilla force. Colonel Usmani insisted, however, that the activities of the guerrillas would be made effective if they could be supported by a number of sector troop units who would keep the Pakistan army units engaged in frontal fights while the guerrillas attacked the enemy units from the flank and the rear.

Following ideas developed by Mao Tse-tung and Che Guevara, most Bengali army leaders realised that guerrillas must get the support of a strong regular formation to defeat a well-entrenched army like that of Pakistan.[11]* Therefore, the strategy of the liberation war, as spelled out in a military paper called the Teliapara Document, was as follows. First, a large guerrilla force would be raised and trained. The task of this force would be to liquidate collaborators of the Pakistan army, destroy communication lines to immobilise the Pakistan forces, and engage in "hit-and-run" operations against convoys and isolated posts of the Pakistan forces to create perpetual tension for them. Second, the regular units of the Mukti Bahini would be enlarged, divided into sector troops, and placed in different areas to give cover to guerrilla operations. Third, the best material among the regular units of the Mukti Bahini and guerrillas would be recruited to form a regular force which would launch full-scale direct attacks on the Pakistan army strongholds once guerrillas and sector troops had demoralised them and cut off their lines of logistic support.[12]

Once the Teliapara Document was approved by the Bangladesh Government-in-exile, as well as by Indian staff officers, a massive programme of recruiting and training of guerrillas was undertaken. The Indian government's decision to help the Bangladesh liberation struggle was conditional on its being led by the Awami League, whose general ideological position was similar to that of India's ruling Congress party. Both the Indian government and the AL had an interest in ensuring that the guerrillas or freedom-fighters being recruited were ideologically loyal to the AL and that young men affiliated to other parties (especially the various Maoist groups) were prevented from infiltrating into the force. A carefully considered procedure for

recruitment was therefore devised. Several hundred youth reception camps were set up along the border areas to recruit young men from Bangladesh. Since educated young men were a favourite target of Pakistan soldiers, a large number of school, college and university students, especially those living in the border areas, crossed into India. Eventually more than 250,000 volunteers reported to the camps for training. At these camps, which were run by Awami League MNAs and MPAs with the help of officers of the Bangladesh Government-in-exile, those with loyalties to parties other than the AL were screened out.

After screening and a period of indoctrination, those re-commended by the AL were accepted by the Indian Army for training at centres in West Bengal, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Tripura and Meghalaya. Here they were instructed in the use of light automatic weapons, mortars and explosives. Initially the training period was for two weeks only, but this was found inadequate and soon extended for another three weeks. Six weeks special training at Chakulia in Bihar was given to those who were to act as guerrilla leaders. By the end of November some 100,000 guerrillas had been sent back to Bangladesh while another 100,000 were still being trained in Indian camps. The vast majority of the guerrillas recruited to the Mukti Bahini were students, drawn primarily from lower middle class and middle class families. Some portion of the guerrillas came from industrial labour,[13] while others were from the families of small businessmen and cultivators.

After the second phase of the revolution about 8,000 armed EBR and police took shelter in the border areas of India, providing the nucleus of the sector troops and brigade forces of Mukti Bahini. There was of course an acute shortage of officers at first. This was partly compensated for by the arrival of 20 Bengali officers who had managed to escape from West Pakistan,[14] partly by the utilisation of a few retired army officers, and partly by requisitioning the services of some Air Force officers. In addition, about 100 battle-hardened guerrillas were selected to undergo short-course officers' training and were commissioned in October.

In order to administer the new army, a regular Armed Forces Headquarters, with ten officers under Commander-in-Chief

Colonel Usmani, was established. Lieutenant-Colonel M.A. Rab was appointed Chief of Staff and Group Captain A.K. Khandokar Deputy Chief of Staff. While Colonel Usmani had his office in India, the Chief of Staff was able to locate his office within Bangladesh.

To implement the Teliapara strategy, Bangladesh was divided into 11 sectors. By the end of November the total number of sector troops was about 10,000. The sector-commanders were as follows: Sector One—at first Major Ziaur Rahman, the nMajor M. Rafiq, Sector Two—at first Major Khaled Musharraf, then Major M. Haider, Sector Three—at first Major Safiullah, then Major Mohammad Nuruzzaman, Sector Four—Major Chittaranjan Dutta, Sector Five—Major Mir Shawkat Ali, Sector Six—Wing Commander M.K. Bashar, Sector Seven—Major Nuruzzaman, Sector Eight—at first Major Osman Choudhury, then Lieutenant-Colonel Mohammad Manzur, Sector Nine—Major M.A. Jalil, Sector Ten—Major Joinal Abedin, and Sector Eleven—Major Abu Taher. The Sector Troops were armed with ordinary infantry weapons supplied by the Indian army. In Sector One, for example, there were one light machine-gun, some medium machine-guns. Rifles, grenades, 2-inch and 3-inch mortars, and anti-tank guns. The sector commanders in general were helped by Indian army brigadiers in chalking out their plans of campaign.

By October, three brigade force—Z force, K force and S force, led respectively by Majors Ziaur Rahman, Khaled Musharraf and M. Safiullah—were raised, for the purpose of launching frontal attacks on the Pakistan strongholds. The brigades were formed by the EBR battalions. Recruitment was made from the best material among the EPR and police, while young men were also selected from among the battle-hardened guerrillas in an attempt to raise the strength of the EBR from five battalions to eight. The fire-power of the Brigade Forces was heavier than that ordinarily supplied to sector troops. Two artillery batteries were also raised. The first battery was armed with some old wartime guns. The second battery was armed with better quality heavy guns, also supplied by the Indian army.

A naval wing of the Mukti Bahini, consisting of 400 naval

commandos, was raised from among Bengali naval officers, warrant officers and *jawans* (naval ratings) who had defected from the Pakistan Navy. For self-defence the naval commandos were additionally equipped with grenades. For operations they were trained in underwater sabotage and in the use of gun-boats and limpet mines. By October a tiny air force had also been created. Two helicopters, an Otter aircraft, and a one-engine Dakota were provided by the Indian Air Force. The two aircrafts were fitted with guns, bombs and rockets. Those Bengali air force officers who were working with the regular units of the liberation army, as well as fifty other Bengali airmen, were given training at Dimapur airport in Nagaland. To escape detection by Pakistan's radar the Bangladesh Air Forcemen had to be trained to fly small aircraft at an altitude below 300 feet.[15]

Mujib Bahini

Because of the massive popular support that the guerrillas received, the new recruits to the Mukti Bahini often emerged as exceedingly popular heroes in Bangladesh. This led to an apprehension, especially amongst the AL, that the leadership would be taken over by the Liberation Armed Forces. This possibility would become more real if Sheikh Mujib did not return from prison. With this in mind, four close confidants of Sheikh Mujib (Tofael Ahmed, Sheikh Fazlul Huq Moni, Serajul Alam Khan, and Abdur Razzak) formed the Mujib Bahini, an armed force organised explicitly to preserve the interests of Sheikh Mujib and his closest supporters. College and university students belonging exclusively to the Students' League were recruited to the Mujib Bahini from youth reception camps throughout 1971, until total strength was reported to have reached 7,000-8,000 in November.

These units were given training by the Indian army in Dehra Dun (in Uttar Pradesh) and in Haphlong (in Assam) in India.[16] The training period was 45 days. Besides being trained in guerrilla warfare, these men were also given political coures on "Mujibism"—projected as Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's ideas on nationalism, secularism, socialism, and democracy. The Mujib Bahini with its own wireless system and special code for communication maintained a separate existence outside

the command of Bangladesh Government-in-exile and Mukti Bahini.[17]

Kader Bahini

While the Mukti Bahini and Mujib Bahini were trained and equipped mainly by the Indian Army, there were a few forces organised within Bangladesh and equipped primarily with weapons snatched from the Pakistan Army. The most effective among these forces was the Bahini (army) organised by Abdul Kader Siddiqui—popularly known as the Kader Bahini. Kader, 25 in 1971 and son of a practising *Muktear* (lawyer of subordinate courts) of Tangail town, was a former Non-Commissioned Officer in the Pakistan Army and an active participant in the 1966 war on the West Pakistan front. He had left the Pakistan Army soon after the war and was a student of the Intermediate Arts class in Karatia College near Tangail in March 1971.

On April 19, when a column of the Pakistan Army moved towards Mymensingh, an EPR-led force put up resistance unsuccessfully near Kalahati. Kader, who had participated in the Kalahati battle with a few of his young friends, then moved around in rural areas and began to collect arms and to organise a resistance force. In the meantime the young men of Tangail, who were special targets of the Pakistan forces, began to pour into Mahanandapur (a jungle terrain between *Madhupr Ghar and Bhawal Ghar* where Kader and his friends had taken shelter).[18] It was the pressure of these young men flocking to Mahanandapur that encouraged Kader further; he began to build a large force in a planned manner.[19]

Kader Bahini men created a stir among the people of Tangail in June when they killed 16 Pakistan soldiers by making a surprise attack on a Pakistan outpost. Another event that further increased people's confidence in Kader Bahini took place on August 11 when a Kader Bahini group attacked a Pakistan boat, carrying a large number of arms and ammunition to North Bengal, with sten-guns, light machine-guns and mortars. The commander of the boat and about 100 soldiers on board were killed. Before Pakistan reinforcements could arrive, Kader Bahini men took away a considerable number of arms and ammunition and set fire to the rest. The blaze of the burning

boat could be seen and the sound of the burning arms and ammunition could be heard for quite a few days, even in distant villages.

After this spectacular operation, the numbers of the Kader Bahini swelled further. In the meantime, Kader established contact with the Government-in-exile and the Indian Army and received from the latter some wireless sets. Ultimately the Kader Bahini became an organised force of some 17,000 young men, consisting of school and college students of the age-group 14-24, mostly of peasant origin. In addition, the auxiliary volunteer force of the Kader Bahini numbered over 72,500, consisting mostly of rural school students. The majority of the 95 company commanders of the Kader Bahini were college students in the age-group 20-24.

Liberation War

Although the Bengali rebels had the advantage of training in India, with weapons supplied by the Indian armed force,[20] there were certain disadvantages in launching guerrilla warfare in Bangladesh. In the literature on modern guerrilla warfare great emphasis is put on the depth of territory of a country in which guerrilla warfare is to be waged. Thus Paret and Shy have written:

> "A determining factor in Arab,Russian and Chinese guerrilla warfare—which also applied to Russian partisan operations during World War II—was the unlimited space available. Gradually, as the enemy's lines extended, he grew more vulnerable to attrition and attack. In such theatres of war, guerrillas traded ground for time. Indeed, Mao declared that since guerrilla warfare requires space for manoeuvreing, it would not be feasible in a small country such as Belgium."[21]

Bangladesh, a country of only 55,126 square miles, does not have the space ideally required for guerrilla manoeuvres. On the contrary, Bangladesh is what Che Guevara would call an "unfavourable terrian"[22] for irregular operations. With the exception of low ranges in the Chittagong Hill Tracts and a few forest areas, Bangladesh comprises a vast plain. The major forested area—the Sundarbans—is the habitat of poisonous snakes

and tigers, criss-crossed by numerous rivulets with man-eating crocodiles, an area virtually unusable by guerrillas as a place for retreat.[23]

A flat deltaic territory, Bangladesh has a population density of over 1,300 per square mile. The difficulties that guerrillas might experience in a densely populated area are obvious. The great number of potential informers, together with military surveillance, identity cards, security checkposts at workplaces and streets, would handicap the movement of armed groups. Moreover, guerrilla operations would bring in their wake massive retaliation which, in a densely populated area, would result in civilian casualties. Guerrillas could therefore be easily alienated from those civilians whose support is crucial for their success. Moreover, the assumption that the Pakistan forces would remain immobilised during the rainy season proved wrong. By using gun boats, the Pakistan army became more mobile than the guerrillas during the summer rains.

Pakistan was also favoured because it could entice some Muslims to its support by religious appeals. Moreover, while the guerrillas, for the immediate future at least, could offer only sweat, blood and tears, the Pakistan forces could offer the prospect of a share in the loot of Hindu shops and permanent possession of Hindu homes and land. Moreover, the exceedingly youthful age structure of the Bangladesh guerrillas also mitigated against the launching of a protracted war. Practitioners and theorists suggest that the age of guerrillas should ideally be between 25 and 35 so that they are mature enough to be thoroughly and coolly conscious of what they are doing, yet young enough to "bear the extraordinary physical and psychic burdens of animal existence". The overwhelming majority of the Bangladesh gurrillas were below 25 years of age. These "romantic guerrillas" were susceptible to two "politico-military" dangers. The first was the great penchant for heroism—"desperadoism" as Mao Tse-tung calls it—while the other was the possibility of being easily frustrated and, therefore, of giving up too soon.

Despite these limiting factors, the Bangladesh guerrillas did manage not only to survive but also effectively to immobilise the Pakistan army. The main reason for the success of guerrilla operations in Bangladesh was the almost total support given by

the people of Bangladesh. Guerrilla warfare, as Guevara has stated, is a struggle of the people.[24] Political mobilisation in the words of Mao:

"is the most fundamental condition for winning the war."

Mao gives the reasons in a simile:

"The people are like water and the army is like the fish."
"With the common people of the whole country mobilised, we shall create a vast sea of humanity and drown the enemy in it..."[25]

Success in guerrilla warfare is, essentially, a concomitant of political conversion. "War is the continuation of politics by other....means."[26]

The ideological war had already been won on March 25. From then onwards the Pakistan army was caught in a vicious circle. If they had used terror on a minimum scale they could not have suppressed the revolution. But as they unleashed indiscriminate terror on a massive scale, they broke down any sense of security that people in Bangladesh might previously have possessed. Besides, brute military suppression confirmed what the Awami League had been proclaiming since the 1960s, that the relationship between West Pakistan and "East Pakistan" was one of oppressive rulers and oppressed citizenry. Both the people and the guerrillas had been fired with nationalistic fervour and had developed a common psychological predisposition. They had in common love of the country, hatred of the Occupation Army a mixture of fanaticism, and an unrelieved sense of insecurity. The guerrillas therefore represented the "real problems, real hopes and real fears" of the people of Bangladesh and were, in the literal sense, "merely the fighting vanguard" of a rebellious people.

The attempt by the Pakistan forces to build a counter-guerrilla force, by recruiting about 100,000 *razakars*, proved as abortive as the several French-inspired operations in Algeria. Although the names of *Razakars* were suggested by the peace committees, guerrillas could easily infiltrate the Razakar Bahini. Except for recruits from the cadres of the Jamaat-i-Islami, the *razakars* did not have the fanaticism and commitment to the Pakistan cause which could help develop in them the under-

ground mentality necessary for counteracting underground guerrillas. Most of the *razakars*, when ecountering Mukti Bahini guerrillas, either fled leaving behind their weapons, or simply raised their hands in surrender. Some of them even joined the Mukti Bahini.

While the guerrillas could derive intelligence easily from the people, Pakistan's forces had to depend on such methods as air observation and informers from the peace committees. Here again, excepting the zealous members of the Jamaat-i-Islami, who unquestionably acted on ideological conviction, most peace committee members were fortune-hunters whose only aim was to share the plunder and loot these could easily be frightened by selective use of terror by guerrillas. As far as possible, guerrillas were sent to their home areas, charged initially with "weeding out open and hidden traitors". By the end of October an estimated 20,000 "collaborators" and their families had been liquidated.[27] The remaining "collaborators" in the rural areas fled to the towns and cities, which were under relatively more effective control by Pakistan forces.

The result was that most of the rural areas now became secure enough to be used by the guerrillas and sector troops providing support to the guerrillas as areas for concealment and retreat.

By November the guerrillas and sector troops could establish their bases deep inside Bangladesh territory. For example, there were about 30,000 guerrillas and sector troops around Dacca.[28] The whole of Rupganj *thana* in Narayanganj subdivision and Savar *thana* in Dacca North subdivision were by then turned into virtual guerrilla camps. In Sector Eight, to take another example, the officers of the sector troops of the Mukti Bahini had established their bases within Bangladesh territory—in Chuadanga, Magura, Narail, Gopalganj, Madaripur, Faridpur, Jessore, Satkhira, in the Sundarbans, in Patuakhali, and in Barisal.[29]

From the liberated areas the guerrillas subsequently launched commando raids on the convoys and isolated posts of the Pakistan military and police forces,[30] capturing weapons and creating perpetual tension. The extent of the success of the guerrilla operations can be gauged from the fact that, by August, 280 of the 400 police stations in Bangladesh had been raided and destroyed by the guerrillas. In Sector Two—comprising the districts of

Dacca, Comilla, Noakhali and Faridpur—all the police stations had by then been raided.[31]

Pakistan troops, numbering more than 25,000 (including the Punjab police and militia) were killed by the guerrillas and their supporting forces during the period from March 25 to December 3, 1971, when war between India and Pakistan finally broke out.[32] The guerrillas captured between 500 and 600 West Pakistan soldiers and several hundred *razakars*. Guerrilla operations carried out in Dacca helped particularly to sustain the morale and to secure support of the Bangladesh people for the Mukti Bahini.

From June 1971 several "crack" platoons of guerrillas launched surprise attacks at regular intervals on West Pakistan army patrol groups, killing people like Abdul Monem Khan,[33] destroying industrial plants belonging to people like Hamidul Huq Choudhury,[34] or simply exploding a grenade in the heart of the city and running away without being caught. On the very day that news of the movement of the U.S. Seventh Fleet in the Bay of Bengal was broadcast from Radio Pakistan, two guerrillas blasted the American Centre in Dacca with a bomb.[35] News of the Mukti Bahini was blacked out from the censored newspapers of "East Pakistan", and from news bulletins broadcast from Radio Pakistan, but broadcasts from the BBC, enjoyed a high degree of credibility and increased the confidence of people in the efforts of the Mukti Bahini.[36]

Rapid communications are the enemy army's greatest weapon against rebels in less rugged areas. Writers on guerrilla warfare have therefore put great emphasis on the need for destruction of this weapon.[37] The main aim of the Bangladesh guerrillas was to disrupt the communication systems so that Pakistan forces could not feed, regroup and reinforce their ranks. By the end of November the guerrillas were able completely to paralyse communications by destroying bridges and railway lines. The Kader Bahini alone, whose areas of operation included the whole of Tangail district and some parts of the districts of Dacca, Mymensingh and Pabna were reported to have had over 350 engagements with Pakistan forces. They also claimed responsibility for killing more than 1,000 West Pakistan soldiers and militiamen, destroying 17 bridges between Dacca and

Tangail, and later mining the diversion roads opened by the West Pakistan forces around those bridges.[38]

While the guerrillas disrupted road and rail communications, the Mukti Bahini frogmen, who started their operations from August 14, made the two ports of Bangladesh—Chittagong and Chalna—almost totally inactive. They sank more than 20 ships, some of which had brought arms and ammunition from West Pakistan. Mukti Bahini gunboats also disrupted enemy river communications, especially in the estuary regions.[39]

These disruptions brought the export of jute, jute goods and tea—the commodities which had previously earned valuable foreign exchange and sustained the West Pakistan economy—to a standstill. When more than 100,000 guerrillas and almost 10,000 supporting sector troops became fully active in Bangladesh in October-November, almost all movement of Pakistan troops had stopped, there was virtually no administration in rural areas, no industry could function and the ports remained idle.

At this point, Pakistan troops, suffering from near-paralysis of action and of will, tactically adopted hedge-hog positions, confining themselves within pill boxes and other fortified enclaves surrounded by concrete bunkers or moats built or dug at enormous expense. Seldom did they emerge at night. Even in daytime they appeared only in large numbers. That the nerves of Pakistan army officers were shattered was made evident by the fact that they started moving their families to West Pakistan from the beginning of October. Then President Yahya himself became unnerved and sought frantically to internationalise the conflict by proposing U.N. observers on the borders of Bangladesh and India throughout October and November.[40] These moves created panic among West Pakistan police and militia and undermined the morale of the rank and file of the Pakistan army.

According to Mao's model of the unfolding of protracted guerrilla warfare (the defensive, stalemate and counter-offensive stages)[41] Bangladesh guerrilla warfare by November had already passed the stage of stalemate and was poised for counter-offensive. In this last phase of war, the guerrilla, according to Mao, is to play a supplementary role, while regular formations, aided by guerrillas in the rear and flank, are to launch frontal attacks on the hedge-hog strongholds of demoralised enemy troops.

With completion of the training and development of three infantry brigades, two artillery batteries and a samall airforce, the Mukti Bahini by November was itself prepared to launch the final counter-offensive. These regular formations, together with the guerrillas and their supporting troops, could possibly have liberated Bangladesh even if Indian forces had not intervened.

Before the war between India and Pakistan started, the Mukti Bahini in Sector 6 had already liberated the territory north of Thakurgaon, Nilphamari and Kurigram and was still advancing. With Mukti Bahini scoring victories, the military junta in Pakistan began to show signs of cracking. A group of Colonels reportedly pressed General Abdul Hamid Khan, Chief of Staff of the Pakistan Army to seek a political solution in view of the heavy losses that the army was incurring especially among its officers. Rumour spread that General Hamid might replace Yahya, so that the former could bypass Bhutto and get Sheikh Mujib released to secure a political settlement.[42] Moreover, Pakistan could no longer afford the costly military operations in Bangladesh. As early as April 1971, Yahya declared a six-month moratorium on payment of external and bilateral debts. The cost of maintaining a 70,000-man Pakistan force in Bangladesh was estimated at $2 million per day.[43] By August-September, it was clear that the Pakistan government would be entirely without foreign exchange reserves in the near future if the "suppression expenses" were not halted.[44] To add to the difficulties of the faction-ridden Pakistan military junta, political movements erupted in Baluchistan and NWFP threatening further disintegration of Pakistan. In the light of all these circumstances, there is some justification in the claims made by the officers of the Mukti Bahini that "if the Indian forces had not come into the war directly, the Mukti Bahini itself would have liberated the country within six months,"[45] or alternatively, that "the Indian Army just walked in when we (the Mukti Bahini) had already finished the job."[46]

The Indian Military Intervention

The Indian government's commitment to the liberation of Bangladesh was implicit in its decision to keep the border open after March 25, allowing Bangladesh evacuees to move into

India's eastern provinces. If the Indian government had prevented the entry of the evacuees, 80 to 90 per cent of whom were Hindus, they would simply have been liquidated, since Pakistan forces were determined to kill all the Hindus of former East Pakistan.[47] It was not that the Indian government inveigled the evacuees by opening up the border, as the Pakistan government alleged. Any government believing in basic democratic values and democracy rather than a "demographic solution" to problems would have done the same. As Indira Gandhi told President Nixon, the vast number of refugees on her hands was "the price India was paying for the tradition of an open society."[48]

Once the evacuees began to stream into India's eastern provinces the Indian government had no alternative but to see that Bangladesh was liberated. Unless Bangladesh became an independent sovereign state the evacuees could never go back to their homes. If the evacuees were to stay permanently in India, it would have been difficult for the Indian government to prevent serious communal riots between Hindus and Muslims in Eastern India. In Assam and Tripura, where tension between Bengalis and non-Bengalis had long existed, fresh settlements of refugees would probably have renewed the movement of "Bengali Kheda" (rounding up of Bengalis) on a massive scale. Moreover, the uprooted Bengali evacuees would have provided a vast reservoir for recruitment of new activities by the radical parties of West Bengal, bent on the destruction of India's "bourgeoisie-landlord" dominated political system.

Obviously, other factors—humanitarian considerations, "the century's greatest opportunity" to humble Pakistan creation of a quiet frontier in Eastern India, and the tremendous economic burden of maintaining and of the ultimate settlement of refugees—played their parts in the Indian government's decision to intervene in favour of Bangladesh. But the most important factor was that the creation of an independent Bangladesh was necessary for the protection of the political system of India. As Indira Gandhi stated during her tour of the United States in November 1971, the Bangladesh crisis was "a real treat to Indian democracy and Indian stability."[49]

The Indian government began to train and equip Bangladesh

guerrillas in order to keep the Bangladesh movement alive, all the while putting pressure on the Pakistan government to release Sheikh Mujib. India also advocated a political settlement "on terms acceptable to the elected representatives of East Bengal, led by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman." That the Pakistan government was not willing to come to terms with Awami League leaders was clear from the fact that Yahya already in September 1971 declared vacant the seats of National Assembly members held by prominent AL leaders, arranged "farcical" by-elections, and, finally, convened a session of the "purged" National Assembly for December. Besides, there were predictions—both in the Indian and Western press—that if the war continued for long, the leadership of the liberation struggle would pass from the centrist AL to more radical groups in Bangladesh. From November 13 Indira Gandhi, therefore, began to assert that time was running out for a negotiated settlement. In the meantime she had made all of the preparations—diplomatic as well as military—to launch a full-scale war with Pakistan.

The Soviet Union had already been displeased with Pakistan because of its continued friendship with China, its cold response to Brezhnev's plan for Asian collective security, and its rejection of Kosygin's scheme for a regional economic grouping. The Soviet Union was the first among the major powers to urge the Pakistan government "to stop bloodshed and repression against the population in East Pakistan and to turn to methods of peaceful political settlement."[50] The People's Republic of China, on the other hand, declared her firm support for the Pakistan government and people "in their just struggle to safeguard state sovereignty and national independence."[51]

Although the Western press in general gave detailed reports about the gruesome happenings in Bangladesh, the government of President Nixon continued to support Pakistan, the "most allied ally" of the United States in Asia. During the middle of 1971 dramatic developments had taken place in Sino-American relations. Dr. Henry A. Kissinger, Assistant to President Nixon for National Security Affairs, visited China via Rawalpindi during the summer of 1971 and Nixon soon after announced his plan to visit China. Dr. Kissinger reportedly stated to the Indian Ambassador in Washington, after his trip to Peking in July,

that China would "intervene" if India attacked Pakistan and that the United States might not come to India's help, as it had in 1962 and 1965 when it had warned China against intervention. All these developments had influenced the political climate in India. India had, since independence, been attached to a policy of nonalignment with the super powers, but the Indira Gandhi government had moved increasingly close to Russia.

In response to America's policy on Bangladesh, Indira Gandhi had accepted a two-year-old standing offer from the Soviet Union to enter into a treaty with India. On August 9, 1971 the Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Co-operation between India and Soviet Russia was signed in New Delhi. Article Nine of the Treaty stated:

> "Each high contracting party undertakes to abstain from giving any assistance to any third party that engages in an armed conflict with the other party. In the event of either being subjected to attack or threat thereof, the high contracting parties shall immediately enter into mutual consultation with a veiw to eliminating this threat and taking appropriate effective measures to ensure the peace and security of their countries."[52]

At the time of signing the Treaty, Gromyko, the Soviet Foreign Minister, offered India an immediate supply of advanced weapons, which according to American estimates, reached a value of $500 million by December 15, 1971.[53]

From April to September Indian staff officers were busily engaged in making preparations in case they were called upon to liberate Bangladesh in a quick and short campaign. Except for one infantry division stationed near Calcutta, the rest of the forces of her Eastern Command were oriented towards the defence of the Himalayan border or were intended for internal security operations in Nagaland at the Mizo Hills. Most of India's Eastern Command divisions were mountain divisions, armed with light weapons and possessing no bridging or other river crossing apparatus. These forces were re-equipped with Russia-supplied amphibian tanks and other weapons necessary for launching a successful campaign in riverine Bangladesh, where the Pakistan army had adopted the defensive tactics of fighting with

heavy automatic weapons from pillboxes and fortified bunkers.[54] The Chief of Staff of the Indian Army sent two divisions from his reserve mountain divisions to strengthen forces on the West Bengal—"East Pakistan" border and had raised a new Corps Headquarters (II Corps) for the control of these divisions under Eastern Command. Two divisions of Indian soldiers in Nagaland and Mizoram were made available for Bangladesh operations under Corps Headquarters (IV Corps), these also being brought from the northern front. The artillery deficiencies of Eastern Command were made up by diversions from other fronts. Two regiments of light tanks (TP-76 Russian amphibians) were put under Eastern Command.

The inter-Services Command in Eastern India, which has always been oriented towards Himalayan operations, was also reorganised. An Advance Headquarters of Eastern Air Command, under an Air Commodore, and an Advance Indian Naval Headquarters, representing the Flag Officer-in-Chief of the Eastern Naval Command at Visakhapatnam, were placed under the headquarters of Eastern Command to ensure the highest degree of coordination between the Army, Air Force and Navy in Bangladesh operations. The operational infrastructure including the widening and surfacing of roads was attended to under monsoon conditions in Silchar and Tripura on the eastern side of Bangladesh. Lastly, massive bridging resources were made available to Eastern Command so that it could lay 10,000 feet of bridging at any time.[55]

It seems that by October the Indian government had taken the decision to intervene militarily. As already indicated, full preparations had been made by the Indian armed forces to launch a campaign in Bangladesh. Now another crucial condition was met which could open the way to war: the successful talks between Indira Gandhi and Premier Kosygin towards the end of September. The joint Soviet-Indian statement of September 29 stated :

> "The Soviet side took into account the statement by the Prime Minister that the government of India is fully determined to take all necessary measures to stop the influx of refugees from East Pakistan into India and ensure that

those refugees who are already in India return to their homeland without delay".[56]

From the last week of September the Soviet press began to detail and condemn Pakistan atrocities in Bangladesh.[57] On October 27, after five-day talks between a Soviet team headed by Soviet Deputy Minister Nickolai Firyubin and top officials of the Indian foreign office, India and the Soviet Union invoked the crucial Article Nine of the Indo-Soviet Treaty.

The Indo-Soviet Treaty, coupled with Soviet support to the Bangladesh liberation movement, created uneasiness among Chinese leaders, with the result that a definite shift took place in Chinese attitudes. President Yahya Khan sent a high-powered delegation, headed by Zulfiker Ali Bhutto, to China in the first week of November. China, however, gave it a cool reception; the Chinese leaders made it clear to Bhutto that China would not intervene militarily in a new Indo-Pakistan war and urged a negotiated settlement of the Bangladesh crisis.[58] The fact that no joint communique was issued after the talks was duly noted by Indian decision-makers.

During her three-week tour abroad—in Belgium, Austria, Great Britain, the U.S., France and West Germany—in October-November 1971, Indira Gandhi got the feeling that none of the Western powers would directly help Pakistan in the event of an Indo-Pakistan conflict over Bangladesh.[59] Indira then decided, it seems to provoke Pakistan to launch attack on India, in order to provide her with an opportunity to liberate Bangladesh through direct military intervention. From the day of her return from abroad, Indira Gandhi became increasingly aggressive in her speeches. On November 13, talking to pressmen at Delhi airport, she stated that while she was on the whole satisfied with her talks with world leaders, she could not say how effective any intervention by them would be in solving the Bangladeh issue without a war.[60]

On November 30, Indira Gandhi told the Indian Parliament that India would not withdraw its troops from the border areas unless Pakistan troops vacated Bangladesh.[61] On December 2 she told Congress party workers in Delhi that India had reached "the point of no return" and repeated her demand that the Pak-

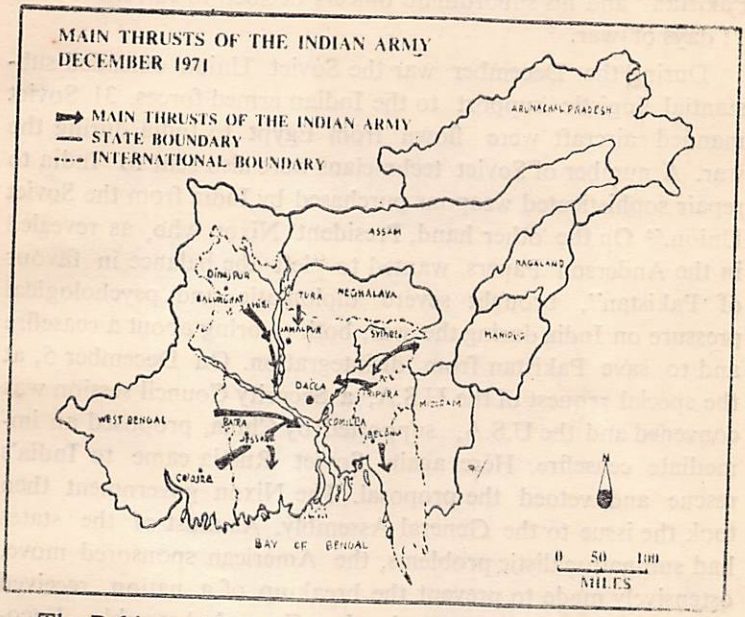
istan army vacate Bangladesh[62] Finally, at a mammoth gathering in Calcutta, Indira Gandhi on December 3 declared that Pakistan troops in Bangladesh were a threat to India's security and war could be avoided only if Pakistan withdrew its troops from Bangladesh.[63] Indeed the war had already begun.

Within a week of her return to India, Indira Gandhi had already given political clearance to Indian forces to cross the borders of "East Pakistan" for "self-interest" or "self-defence."[64] From November 20 the Indian army, together with regular units of the Mukti Bahini, launched attacks in a number of areas in Jessore, Sylhet, Rangpur, Dinajpnr and Comilla districts.[65] On November 21 a fierce tank and artillery battle took place around Boyra on the border of Jessore district, between Indian and Pakistan forces. Pakistan and Indian Air Force planes were engaged in combat and three PAF Sabre Jets were shot down by IAF Gnats.

By November 23, when President Yahya proclaimed an emergency in Pakistan, the village of Chaugacha, five to six miles inside Bangladesh territory, was under the control of Indian and Mukti Bahini troops. On the same day Indian 130-mm guns of Soviet origin began shelling Jessore Airport. Indian and Mukti Bahini troops were also holding pockets of territory in Sylhet and Comilla districts by this time. As the Indian and Mukti Bahini forces continued their offensive in several areas, President Yahya in desperation ordered full scale war on India. On December 3 the formal war between India and Pakistan started.

India, having no significant military objective on the Western Front, took only "defensive-offensive" actions there. On the Eastern Front seven divisions of Indian forces, under the command of Lieutenant-General Jagjit Singh Aurora, launched an attack on Pakistan forces from several directions just before daybreak on December 4. In the Calcutta region II Corps made thrusts into Kushtia, Jessore and Khulna areas. From the North XXXII Corps advanced through Ruhea and Hili and Dinajpur districts and Lalmonirhat in Rangpur district. A brigade from Tura in Meghalaya moved towards Jamalpur in Mymensingh. On the eastern side of Bangladesh, IV Corps mounted an offensive in Sylhet, Comilla and Noakhali districts. By Decem-

ber 6, the morale of the Pakistan forces in Bangladesh had broken. The Indian Navy placed a siege over the entire Bay of Bengal. An Indian aircraft carrier, the *I.N.S Vikranta,* guarded Chittagong port.



The Pakistan Air Force in Bangladesh had only one squadron (14) of Sabre Jets. A few of them had already been destroyed by the end of November. Most of the remaining aircrafts were destroyed on the very first day of the war. Through continuous air attacks on December 4 and 5 the Indian Air Force made all 11 airports of Bangladesh unworkable and three of the remaining Sabre Jets of the Pakistan Air Force remained in their hangers. IAF planes also destroyed river *ghats* (docks) and ferries used by the Pakistan army all over Bangladesh.

Once Bangladesh's air space had been liberated, Indian forces used the same tactics as the Pakistanis had used during the second phase of the Bangladesh revolution. They resorted to parachute drops, helicopter ferrying of troops across rivers and airstrafing of enemy concentrations. General Maneckshaw's repeated broadcasts that all lines of logistic support for Pakistan forces from outside had been completely cut off and that there-

fore Pakistan forces had better surrender, destroyed their already flagging morale. After some initial hesitation, Lieutenant-General A.K. Niazi, C-in-C of the Pakistan Army in "East Pakistan" and his subordinate officers decided to surrender after 11 days of war.

During the December war the Soviet Union extended substantial logistic support to the Indian armed forces. 31 Soviet manned aircraft were flown from Egypt to India during the war. A number of Soviet technicians were also sent to India to repair sophisticated weapons purchased by India from the Soviet Union.[66] On the other hand, President Nixon who, as revealed in the Anderson Papers, wanted to "left the balance in favour of Pakistan", brought severe diplomatic and psychological pressure on India during the war, both to bring about a ceasefire and to save Pakistan from disintegration. On December 5, at the special request of the U.S.A, a Security Council session was convened and the U.S.A, supported by China, proposed an immediate ceasefire. Here again Soviet Russia came to India's rescue and vetoed the proposal. The Nixon government then took the issue to the General Assembly. As most of the states had sub-nationalistic problems, the American sponsored move, ostensively made to prevent the break-up of a nation, received the support of 104 states in the General Assembly. Encouraged by almost total suppot in the General Assembly, the Nixon government on December 10 ordered a few ships of the U.S. Seventh Fleet including the nuclear-powered aircraft carrier *USS Enterprise*, to move from the Tonkin Gulf towards the Indian Ocean. The Soviet Union then deployed some 35 ships and submarines—the largest number the Soviet Union had ever sent into the Indian Ocean at any one time—to effectively counteract the presence of eight ships of the Seventh Fleet. Moscow also threatened to open up a diversionary military action in Sinkiang—44 Soviet Divisions were posted along or close to Sino-Soviet border—if the Chinese moved to interfere militarily in favour of Pakistan.[67]

Role of The Mukti Bahini

Some Indian and foreign journalists compared the Indian advance in Bangladesh with the German Blitzkrieg across France in 1940.

Pakistan's mistakes, they argued, were the same as those of France. The Pakistan Army relied on the Maginot line strategy, sticking doggedly to prepared bunkers, concrete defence works and barbed wire entanglements across the main roads. The Indians almost invariably attacked through the fields, along dust tracks or along rivers. They used small tanks, armoured personnel carriers, jeeps and gunboats. The Indian forces also commandered tiny *rickshaws* and motorised *trishaws* (motorised scooter rickshaws). Small field-guns and rocket launchers were screwed into vehicles and raced into position. A.K. Niazi, a "poor general", never seemed to have expected this. The Pakistan army, mistaking rapid and bewildering movements for large forces, tamely surrendered.[68]

However, the quick success of the Indian Army was made possible by the work already done by the Mukti Bahini and the share of fighting undertaken by them in the December war. As has been stated above, the Mukti Bahini guerrillas and sector troops had already immobilised the Pakistan forces in Bangladesh before the full-scale war between India and Pakistan started. Moreover, a Joint Command of the Indian Armed Forces and Mukti Bahini was formed before the war between India and Pakistan broke out.[69]

The Joint Command had already worked out a co-ordinated plan to bring about a quick end to the war. The Indian forces with tanks, artillery and airforce would launch direct attacks on the main bases whlie the Mukti Bahini guerrillas and sector troops would "outflank" and attack from the sides or rear. Since the latter was a light force, familiar with the territory, and with strong political motivation, it could work with speed, ferocity and flexibility.

This strategy, based on Usmani's Teliapara proposals (vide p.112), was effective in isolating the strong points of the Pakistan forces and prevent their reinforcement by men, arms and ammunition.

To cite one of many examples, in Ashuganj a single battalion of EBR and some Mukti Bahini guerrillas encircled and rendered ineffective the entire 14th Division of the Pakistan Army. This strategy likewise prevented the strategic retreat of Pakistan troops from outlaying posts to the "Dacca Bowl" to fight a last,

long-drawn battle. It also helped the main columns of the Indian army to bypass many of the Pakistan strongholds and reach Dacca within the shortest possible time.[70] Apart from its vital role in outflanking and encircling the Pakistan bases, the Mukti Bahini furnished reliable intelligence as to the exact positions of Pakistan bunkers, ambushes and road blocks, thus enabling Indian attacks to be accurate and very swift. In areas which it liberated unaided, the Mukti Bahini followed solely its own plans. These areas included Kurigram and Lalmonirhat in north Bengal; Sunamganj and Habiganj in Sylhet, Comilla, Akhuara and the northern side of Brahmanbaria; "axes of advance" in Koberhat, Hayaki and Hathajari in Chittagong; Alamdanga, Chuadanga and Meherpur in Kushtia; Manirumpur and Abhoynagar of Jessore; Bagerhat, Satkhira and Kaliganj in Khulna; Madaripur, Gopalganj and Faridpur in Faridpur district; Barisal and Patuakhali, and "axes of advance" in Brahmanbaria, Bhairab and Narsingdi areas in the final stages of the war.[71]

Joint action was evident in a small but significant respect even in the war from the air. The very first air attack on Bangladesh was launched by the Bangladesh air force. On December 1, Group Captain Chanden Singh, IAF base Commander of Jorhat, flew to Dimapur, where the Bangladesh airmen were being trained. Group Captain Singh told the Bangladesh airmen that Pakistan had planned an attack on India for December 3. The Indian government had decided that the Bangladesh air force would start the war in the Eastern Front so that the Big Powers and other nations could not pin the blame on the Indians. The first targets of the Bangladesh air force would be the Chittagong fuel dump and the Goldai fuel dump at Narayanganj. The Bangladesh air force officers responded enthusiastically to the proposal. Flight Lieutenant Shamsul Alam was selected for the Chittagong mission with Captain M. Akram as co-pilot.

These officers started their "operation kilo" in two small aircrafts at 0100 hours on the night of December 3. Flying at a very low altitude to avoid Pakistan radar, the Bangladesh airmen hit the exact positions of the fuel dumps at Chittagong and Narayanganj, causing them to burst into flames. The Pakistan anti-aircraft guns barked in vain and the Bangladesh aircrafts

returned safely to Dimapur. Besides these two first missions, the Bangladesh air force gave support to advancing Mukti Bahini in several areas and intercepted communications among enemy troops. As the Bangladesh airmen knew the exact positions of Pakistan airbases, airfields, the river *ghats* in Bangladesh, one Bengali officer was taken as co-pilot in each of the IAF planes for every sortie.[72]

The Mukti Bahini and the Indian forces thus played equally important and complementary roles in bringing the liberation war to a swift end. The Indian armed forces performed the role which, according to Teliapara document, was to be played by the regular formations of the Mukti Bahini. On December 16, 1971, General Niazi surrendered on behalf of Pakistan forces in Bangladesh then numbering about 93,000 including West Pakistan police and militia. The surrender was formamlised at Ramna Race Course in Dacca, the very place where Sheikh Mujib had declared on March 7, 1971 that the struggle of the Bengalis this time was for "complete emancipation and independence."

NOTES

1. N. Machiavelli, *The Prince and the Discourses* (New York: Modern Library, 1940), p. 81, quoted in C. Johnson, *Revolutionary Change*, (Boston: Little, Brown and Co., 1966), p. 90.
2. Interview with Tajuddin Ahmed on 29 August 1973.
3. Based on interviews with K. Subrahmanyam, Director, The Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses, New Delhi, on 13 February 1973, and Tajuddin Ahmed on 28 March 1973.
4. According to Tajuddin Ahmed, a Declaration of Independence was prepared by himself and Kamal Hossain on March 25, 1971. But Sheikh Mujib did not sign it (Interview with Tajuddin Ahmed on 29 August 1973). A few days before March 25, Sheikh Mujib told one of the intellectuals, an old associate of the Awami League, that he did not expect large-scale genocide by the Pakistan army.
5. Taufiq Elahi Choudhury, CSP and SDO, Meherpur, who himself led the resistance movement in that subdivision and maintained civil administration for some time in the name of Bangladesh, arranged the ceremonial function at "Mujibnagar". He later joined the regular units of the Mukti Bahini.

6. For the full text of the Declaration of Independence see *Bangladesh Documents* (Madras, The BNK Press, 1971) pp, 281-282.
7. The portfolios of the Ministers were as follows: Mansoor Ali, Finance; Khandokar Mushtaq Ahmed, Foreign Affairs; A. H. M. Kamruzzaman, Relief and Rehabilitation.
8. These figures were quoted to the author by a Deputy Secretary of the Bangladesh Government-in-exile.
9. Justice Abu Sayeed Choudhury was Vice-Chancellor of Dacca University, and was in Europe attending a conference when the military crackdown took place in Bangladesh. Justice Chowdhury defected in favour of the Bangladesh Government-in-exile.
10. Interview with Tajuddin Ahmed on 29 August 1973.
11. Thus, Mao Tse-tung had written: "Of the three strategic stages (the defensive, the stalemate and the counter-offensive) in the entire process of the war in the country as a whole, the first and last are stages in which regular warfare is primary and guerrilla warfare supplementary. In the intermediate stage guerrilla warfare will become primary and regular warfare supplementary....If we take the war as a whole, therefore, regular warfare is primary and guerrilla warfare supplementary". *Selected Military Writings of Mao Tse-tung* (Peking: Foreign Languages Press, 1966), pp. 279-280. According to Che Guevara: "Guerrilla combat is a phase of warfare that cannot of itself attain complete victory....When the guerrilla army acquires a regular status, then it will be ready for dicisive attacks on the enemy and thus secure victory. The triumph will always be the product of the regular army, even though the regular army had its origins in a guerrilla force." See Ernesto "Che" Guevara, "La Guerra de Guerrillas," in X.F.M. Osaka (ed.), *Modern Guerrilla Warfare* (New York: The Free Press, 1962), p. 338.
12. This paragraph is based on interviews with Colonel Safiullah, Chief of Staff, Bangladesh Armed Forces on 12 July 1972 and with Colonel Khaled Musharraf on 28 August 1973.
13. Abdul Mannan, General Secretary of the Jatio Sramik League, claimed that 30,000 workers belonging to the Sramik League fought as Freedom-Fighters. See *Dainik Bangla* (Dacca), January 1, 1972.
14. There were about 1,100 Bengali officers and 28,000 Bengali soldiers in West Pakistan during the period of occupation.
15. See special interview with Air Commodore A.K. Khandker, Chief of Staff, Bangladesh Air Force, in the *Dainik Bangla*, December 3, 1972.
16. Interviews with several members of Mujib Bahini in March 1972. See also special interview with Sheikh Fazlul Huq Moni, *Dainik Bangla* (Dacca), December 4, 1972.

17. It is an intriguing phenomenon of the liberation war that the Indian government allowed the Mujib Bahini to work outside the authority of the Bangladesh Government-in-exile. It is also significant that Major-General Sujan Singh Ovan (Retired), who had been in overall charge of the training programme of the Mujib Bahini, was the only senior retired officer decorated with the Param-Ati-Vishishta-Seva medal by the Indian government after the liberation war. See Lieutenant-Colonel Nuruzzaman, "The Government and the People: Some Vital Questions," *Holiday* (Dacca), June 18, 1972. Nuruzzaman was commander of Sector 7 of the Mukti Bahini during the war.
18. Madhupur Ghar (jungle) is in Mymensingh district, bordering Tangail district and Bhawal Ghar is in Dacca district, bordering Tangail district, Mahanandapur ultimately became the headquarters of the Kader Bahini.
19. Interview with Abdul Kader Siddiqui on 30 August 1973.
20. It was alleged by some that arms supplied to the Mukti Bahini were given by the governments of Russia and East European countries, with the permission of the Indian government.
21. P. Paret and J.W. Shy, *Guerrillas in the 1960s* (New York: Frederic A. Praeger, 1962), pp. 28-29, Mao Tse-tung has written: "Given an extensive area, guerrilla warfare can be developed and sustained even in the plains, not to mention the river-lake-estuary regions. By and large, the vastness of China's territory and enemy shortage of troops provided guerrilla warfare in China with this condition. This is an important, even a primary condition, as far as the possibility of waging guerrilla warfare is concerned and small countries like Belgium, which lack this condition, have few or no such possibilities." *Selected Military Writings of Mao Tse-tung* (Peking: Foreign Language Press, 1966), p. 173.
22. See Guevara, "La Guerra de Guerrillas", pp. 345-348.
23. Soon after the formation of the Government-in-exile, Tajuddin Ahmed asked one of his officers in the Ministry of Defence, who himself had led popular resistance during the second phase of the revolution in his subdivision, to make a study and report on the feasibility of guerrilla warfare in Bangladesh. After reading various classics on the general subject including Clausewitz, Lawrence, Mao and Guevara, the officer himself felt pessimistic. He reported to Tajuddin that there was no prospect of success of guerrilla warfare in Bangladesh and advised that it would be better to work for the intervention of the Indian Army.
24. E. C. Guevara, *op. cit.*, p. 337.
25. Quoted in Katzenbach, E. L. and Hanraphan, G. Z., "The Revolutionary Strategy of Mao Tse-tung," in Osaka, *op. cit.*, pp. 136-137.

26. Lenin was quick to see Clausewitz's point. See Lenin's *Collected Works* (Moscow: Progress Publishers, 1964), Vol. XXI, p. 304.
27. R. Sobhan, "Bangladesh's Liberation War: An Analysis," *Morning News* (Dacca), January 10, 1972.
28. Interview with Brigadier Khaled Musharraf on 28 August 1973.
29. See special interview with Lieutenant-Colonel Manzur in *Dainik Bangla* (Dacca), December 10, 1972.
30. About 10,000 Punjab police and militia were brought from West Pakistan around the middle of 1971. They were first deployed in police stations raided by Mukti Bahini. Later they were deployed in border areas to check the infiltration of guerrillas.
31. Interview with Brigadier Khaled Musharraf on 28 August 1973.
32. This figure of 25,000 is quoted by General Usmani. See *The People* (Dacca), April 23, 1972. Major-General Safiullah and Brigadier Khaled Musharraf also quoted the same figure when the author interviewed them. According to them, the figure is based on the receipts of insurance money sent from Dacca post office to the families of killed soldiers, militia and policemen in West Pakistan. The total casualties of the Mukti Bahini, including the casualties during the war from December 3 to December 16, were only 2,000 or so.
33. Abdul Monem Khan was the Governor of East Pakistan for 7 years under the Ayub regime.
34. Hamidul Huq Choudhury, a leading lawyer of Dacca and a former Foreign Minister of Pakistan, reportedly worked against the Bangladesh movement and kept contact with General Yahya Khan.
35. For details of the guerrilla operations in Dacca see H.H. Morshed. *Daccaye Gerrilla Operation* [Guerrilla Operation in Dacca], (Dacca: Nowroz Kitabistan, 1972).
36. During the last years of the Ayub decade, the government arranged for the import of large numbers of transistors from abroad in order to step up the publicity campaign about the "development decade". These transistors particularly helped the politicisation of rural people, who commonly listened to BBC, All-India Radio and Radio Peking.
37. See for example, E.C. Guevara, *op. cit.*, p. 371.
38. See special interview with Kader Siddiqui, *Dainik Bangla*, December 8, 1972.
39. See General Usmani's statement in *The People* (Dacca), April 23, 1972.
40. See G. W. Choudhury, "The Emergence of Bangladesh and the South Asian Triangle," *Year Book of World Affairs*, 1973 (London, Stevens and Sons, 1973), p. 79.

41. See "The Three Stages of Protracted War", in *Selected Military Writings*...., pp. 210-219.
42. Lawrence Ziring, "Militarism in Pakistan: The Yahya Khan-Interregnum," W.H. Wriggings (ed.) *Pakistan in Transition* (Islamabad, Islamabad, University Press, 1975), p. 211.
43. Robert La Porte, Jr., "Pakistan in 1971: The Disintegration of a Nation", *Asian Survey*, XII, No. 2, (February 1972), p. 102, Footnote 37, p. 106.
44. G. W. Choudhury, *India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and the Major Powers: Politics of a Divided Subcontinent* (New York, The Free Press, 1975). p. 208.
45. See special interview with General Usmani, *Dainik Bangla* (Dacca) December 8, 1972.
46. This was the concluding sentence of Brigadier Khaled Musharraf when the author interviewed him on 28 August 1973 at his residence in Kurmitola cantonment.
47. About 6.8 million evacuees were maintained in 896 temporary camps, established and maintained by a special organisation headed by Colonel N.P. Luthra, under the Ministry of Relief and Rehabilitation, Government of India. The remaining evacuees (about 3 million) who found shelter with friends and relatives were also registered with Colonel Luthra's organisation and provided with rations and medical assistance from the camps. See M.F. Franda, "Refugees and Migration Patterns in North-eastern India and Bangladesh," *AUFS Fieldstaff Reports*, XVI : 3 (1972), pp. 6-7.
48. D. Mullick, *Indira speaks on Genoicde, War and Bangladesh* Calcutta Academic Publishers, 1972), p. 52.
49. *Ibid.*, p. 55.
50. See *Supplement to Soviet Review*, IX : 3 (January 8, 1972), pp. 8-9.
51. See M. Ayoob and K. Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War* (New Delhi : S. Chand and Co., 1972), pp. 153-154.
52. *The Pakistan Observer* (Dacca), October 23, 1971.
53. *The Christian Science Monitor*, December 16, 1971.
54. See *Frontier* (Calcutta), IV: 19 (August 21, 1972) p. 3.
55. For a detailed and professional discussion of the "feverish" preparations made by the Indian forces during the period April-September see Major General D.K. Palit, *The Lightning Campaign: Indo-Pakistan War 1971* (New Delhi: Thomson Press, 1972). pp. 63-75.
56. *Supplement to Soviet Review*, IX : 3 (January 18, 1972).
57. "Articles from The Soviet Press," in *Ibid.*, pp. 26-42.
58. G. W. Choudhury, "The Emergence of Bangladesh....", *op. cit.* pp. 76-77.

59. During the time of Indira Gandhi's tour of the United States. Secretary of State William Rogers made a statement that the US would keep itself out of any Indo-Pakistan conflict. See Mullick, *op. cit.*, p. 61.
60. *loc. cit.*
61. *Ibid.*, p. 63.
62. *Ibid.*, pp. 66, 68.
63. *Ibid.*, pp. 70, 72.
64. G.W. Choudhury, *op. cit.*, p. 80.
65. D. H. Bayley, "India: War and Political Assertion," *Asian Survey* XII, 2, (February 1972), pp. 93-94.
66. See *Frontier* (Calcutta), IV : 36 (December 18, 1971).
67. R.C. Thornton, "South Asia: Imbalance in the Subcontinent"- *Orbis*, XIX, 3 (Fall, 1975), pp. 868-869.
68. For this line of analysis see, for example, Major-General D.K. Palit. *op. cit.*, see also *The Sunday Times* (London), December 12, 1971, *Frontier* (Calcutta) IV : 37 (December 25, 1971).
69. The Joint Command worked on informal basis until December 6 when the Indian Government extended formal recognition to the Government of Bangladesh. The Joint Command was given a formal shape soon after the recognition. Syed Nazrul Islam and Tajuddin Ahmed, Acting President and Prime Minister of the Bangladesh Government-in-exile respectively, signed the document of the Joint Command on behalf of Bangladesh. General Maneckshaw and D.P. Dhar signed it on behalf of the Indian government. In that document the Indian forces were described as "supporting forces". See special interview with General Usmani, *Dainik Bangla* (Dacca) December 5, 1972.
70. *Ibid.*
71. *Ibid.*
72. See Group Captain Bashar, "The Unsung Heroes" and Flight Lieutenant Shamsul Alam, "Operation Kilo," in *The Bangladesh Observer*, Air Force Day Supplement, September 28, 1972.